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DJIA 48185.80 ▲ 275.88 0.58% NASDAQ 22822.42 ▲ 0.8% STOXX 600 612.59 ▼ 0.1% 10-YR. TREAS. (Reopening) yield 4.292% OIL \$97.87 ▲ \$3.46 GOLD \$4,792.20 ▲ \$42.70 EURO \$1.1700 YEN 158.98

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **The S&P 500 rose 0.6%**, advancing for a seventh consecutive session on optimism that the U.S. can reach a longer-term peace deal with Iran. The Nasdaq and Dow rose 0.8% and 0.6%, respectively. **B9**
- ◆ **Monthly price increases** as measured by the Fed's preferred gauge sped up in February, showing that inflation remained persistent even before the Iran war began. **A2**
- ◆ **Coreweave expanded** an agreement with Meta Platforms, providing the company with AI cloud capacity through December 2032 for about \$21 billion. **B1**
- ◆ **Meta Platforms** removed from Facebook and Instagram ads that law firms were using to recruit potential plaintiffs to suits targeting the social-media platform. **B1**
- ◆ **Sazerac approached** Brown-Forman about a potential deal, an overture that came as Brown-Forman was in deal talks with French spirits maker Pernod Ricard. **B1**
- ◆ **VW will stop** producing the ID.4 electric crossover at its Tennessee assembly plant as the U.S. auto industry retreats from EVs. **B1**
- ◆ **A Carlyle private-credit fund** was hit by redemption requests totaling 15.7%, contributing to recent wobbles on that corner of Wall Street. **B9**
- ◆ **American Airlines** became the latest carrier to increase bag fees as the industry contends with a rapid run-up in the price of fuel. **A2**
- ◆ **The parent of 7-Eleven** projected a drop in net profit and pushed back the planned listing of its North American convenience-store business. **B3**

Worldwide

- ◆ **The U.S. worked** to keep Israel's war in Lebanon from derailing talks with Iran this weekend, with Trump asking Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu to scale back attacks that were threatening a fragile cease-fire. **A1, A6-7**
- ◆ **The White House** warned staff against improperly leveraging their positions to place bets on prediction markets after well-timed wagers on the war by unidentified accounts raised eyebrows. **A5**
- ◆ **The Justice Department** opened an investigation into whether the NFL engaged in anticompetitive tactics amid complaints about the cost of watching football. **A1**
- ◆ **Melania Trump denied** having ties to Jeffrey Epstein and called on Congress to hold a public hearing for his victims in a surprise announcement at the White House. **A5**
- ◆ **Britain's military** exposed a Russian submarine operation carrying out malign activity against the U.K.'s undersea infrastructure, such as pipelines and telecom cables. **A9**
- ◆ **A federal judge** ruled that the Defense Department failed to comply with an earlier order to restore Pentagon access for journalists, a setback for the Trump administration. **A5**
- ◆ **GSK withdrew** its application for a drug that Trump touted last year as a potential treatment for autism symptoms just months after submitting it. **A3**
- ◆ **Argentina's legislature** revised a statute that protects glaciers, potentially allowing provinces to ease its provisions in a way that would encourage more copper mining. **A9**

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WHEE HAMZEH/SHUTTERSTOCK

As Israel continued to hit Beirut on Thursday, people returned to areas it pounded on Wednesday to scavenge belongings.

Netanyahu Keeps on Fighting, But the Payoff Remains Unclear

Battlefield victories haven't translated into diplomatic plan to help secure peace

By ANAT PELED

JERUSALEM—Just before 1 a.m. Wednesday in Israel, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu received a phone call from President Trump, who told him that he was about to announce a cease-fire.

The Israeli leader agreed to participate. But Israel, which wasn't formally part of the negotiations, wasn't happy that it was learning of the com-

pleted deal so late in the process, said a person briefed on the conversation and mediators in the conflict. Netanyahu had time to get in one important request: We need to keep going in Lebanon, the person briefed on the call said.

He got the green light from Trump, the person said, and Israel launched an air attack on Lebanon, hitting 100 targets in 10 minutes. The strikes led to a furious response from Iran that shook the fragile hours-old cease-fire as Iran rained rockets and drones on targets around the region.

Netanyahu positioned himself as Israel's warrior king after the Hamas-led Oct. 7, 2023,

attacks on Israel and has kept up the fight for more than two and a half years.

For many in Israel, fatigue is growing over living in a constant state of war, and there is mounting criticism that despite the success on the battlefield the country hasn't yet won the war.

The fighting in Lebanon is testing the cease-fire, with Iran saying its allies in the region were supposed to be part of the deal. Vice President JD Vance said Wednesday the Iranian statement suggested a misunderstanding. Netanyahu said Thursday that Israel would open direct negotiations with Lebanon over Hez-

bollah's disarmament.

Netanyahu has said Israel must keep going in Lebanon to protect those in northern Israel from Hezbollah's attacks. The militants have fired thousands of rockets and drones at Israel since joining the war.

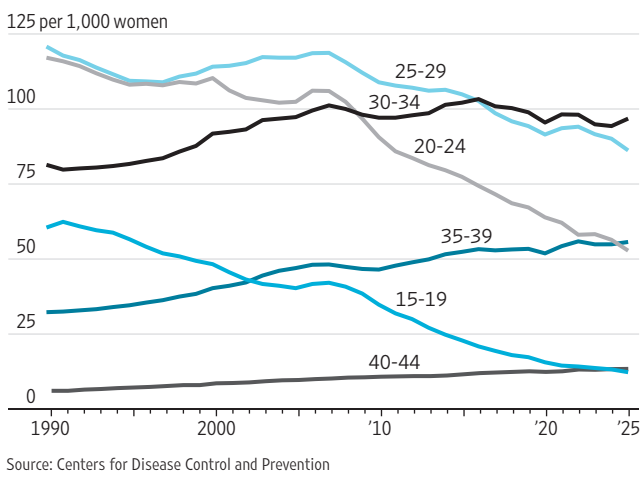
That Israel sees a need to continue the fight shows that it still sees Hezbollah as a potent threat. In Gaza, Hamas is resisting pressure to disarm despite getting pounded for more than two years. And some are now saying the five-week war against Iran didn't deliver the setbacks to Iran's nuclear program, ballistic missiles and regime that Netan-

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U.S. Birthrate at Record Low

The number of births per 1,000 women ages 15 to 44—the general fertility rate—reached a record low of 53.1 in 2025. The rate has mostly headed down since 2007. **A3**

U.S. birthrates by age group



Source: Centers for Disease Control and Prevention

DOJ Opens Probe Into NFL Over Its Media-Rights Deals

By JESSICA TOONKEL AND DANA MATTIOLI

The Justice Department has opened an investigation into whether the National Football League has engaged in anticompetitive tactics amid complaints that watching football has become too expensive, according to people familiar with the situation.

The Sports Broadcasting Act, passed in 1961, grants the league limited antitrust protection that allows teams to collectively negotiate packages of TV rights. Media compa-

nies, regulators and members of Congress raised concerns in recent months about how difficult and pricey it has become for consumers to watch their favorite sports, in part because of deals in which leagues offer smaller packages of games to streamers.

The nature and scope of the federal investigation couldn't be learned.

Spokesmen for the Justice Department and the NFL declined to comment.

The NFL said it is the most fan- and broadcast-friendly league, with 87% of its games

available on local TV. When NFL games are shown on streaming services, they are also available in the local TV markets of the teams playing.

The 2025 season was its most viewed since 1989, the league said, a reflection of "the strength of the NFL distribution model and its wide availability to all fans."

The fresh scrutiny of the NFL comes as the cost of rights to air high profile sporting events rises, propelled in part by demand from deep-pocketed technology

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Surging HOA Fees Pinch Homeowners

By NICOLE FRIEDMAN

Donald DeFesi's monthly fees for his condominium association in Walnut Creek, Calif., have more than doubled since 2015 to \$1,500. He now pays more each month for his association fees, condo insurance and property taxes than he does for the principal and

interest on his mortgage. "I certainly didn't expect the homeowners association dues to increase as they have," DeFesi said.

People in the U.S. are paying more than ever to homeowners associations, adding to the mounting costs that are driving many would-be buyers out of the housing market.

The median monthly condo fee was \$420 in 2025, up 29% from 2019, according to a Realtor.com analysis of for-sale listings. For single-family homeowners, median HOA fees rose 26% from 2019 to \$63 last year.

HOA and condo fees aren't the biggest expense in many

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How to Make Money Running A Gas Station: Put in a Speakeasy

* * *

One of the hottest tables in town is hidden behind the cooler inside a Minnesota Amoco

By JENNIFER WILLIAMS

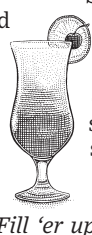
People cross city and state lines to wait a couple of hours for a drink at the Farmer's Celler.

They order \$18 mezcal cocktails infused with shiitake mushrooms, red onion and jalapeño herb oil. Between rounds, they

might sample crispy pork belly or a \$45 espresso-dusted ribeye.

But what really separates the Lakeville, Minn., eatery from other hot spots is the location: inside an Amoco station.

"You go into the gas station, as weird as it



Fill 'er up

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INSIDE



MANSION

A 'Shark Tank' star's \$200 million property empire, from New York to Australia. **M1**

Smaller Colleges Risk Extinction

Big-name campuses turn away students, others struggle to fill seats

By DOUGLAS BELKIN

COLCHESTER, Vt.—The financial troubles at St. Michael's College hit home for biology professor Declan McCabe when he noticed Buckthorn shrubs encroaching on walking trails near the house of the campus president.

Enrollment declines opened the door to maintenance staff reductions, giving the invasive shrub the upper hand. McCabe—a roll-up-your-sleeves, get-it-done Irishman—taught his students to identify the woody plant and cut it back with handsaws and loppers. He turned the chore into lessons on the environment.

Tenured professors doubling as groundskeepers at a \$70,000-a-year private college in New England is an-

other sign of what is shaping up as the bleakest era for America's smaller private schools.

Consolidation of the nation's nearly trillion-dollar higher-education sector is driving a new winner-take-all market, benefiting Ivy League campuses, flagship public universities and schools with high-profile sports teams and renowned research institutions. They enjoy high demand and a surplus of full-tuition payers, while lesser-known campuses juggle cost cuts and steep tuition discounts, including at St. Michael's, to fill seats.

Shrinking enrollment at 442 private nonprofit colleges—out of 1,700 nationwide—is placing them at sig-

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